

Chapter 54: The Moment You Can't Stay Halfway

Jenny didn't speak to Austin that morning.

Not because she was avoiding him.

But because she didn't trust what would come out if she did.

So she worked.

She cleaned.

She served.

She moved.

And in between each task, there were small pauses she didn't notice at first—moments where her hands stopped before they needed to, where her eyes lingered too long on nothing in particular, where she forgot what she was about to do next.

It wasn't distraction.

It was something sitting underneath everything she touched.

Austin noticed, of course.

He always did.

But he didn't interrupt her anymore.

Not the way he used to.

He stayed near the counter, occasionally speaking to staff, occasionally checking something on his phone, but never stepping into her rhythm the way he once would have.

He wasn't trying to stabilize the space between them now.

He was just... in it.

And letting her feel it as it was.

It was near closing when she finally snapped.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

But suddenly enough that even she heard it before she finished saying it.

"Stop looking at me like that."

The movement in the restaurant slowed for half a beat.

A chair scraped somewhere too loudly after the silence.

Bao glanced up but didn't intervene.

Austin looked at her the way he had been looking all day—steady, unchanged.

"Like what?" he asked.

Jenny's fingers tightened around the cloth she was holding. It didn't matter that it was already dry.

"Like you already know what I'm going to say."

Silence settled again, heavier this time.

Austin moved closer.

Not quickly.

Not to corner her.

Just enough that the distance changed in a way she immediately felt.

"I don't know what you're going to say," he said.

A pause.

"But I know what you're avoiding saying."

That made her breath catch slightly, sharp and small.

Jenny shook her head once, like she could physically push the moment away.

"I don't like this version of you."

Austin didn't react like someone being accused.

There was no defense in his expression.

Just acknowledgment.

"I know."

A pause.

"But I don't think I can go back."

The words didn't land as a statement of intention.

They landed as something already finished deciding itself.

Jenny's voice dropped without her meaning to soften it.

"You used to make space for me."

"I still am," Austin said.

A beat.

"But I'm not stepping out of it anymore just to make it easier to stand in."

Silence.

Jenny looked at him for a moment too long before she answered, like she was checking whether he meant it or whether it would shift if she stared hard enough.

It didn't.

"Then what am I supposed to do with you?" she asked.

Austin didn't answer immediately.

He didn't seem to be searching for the right words anymore. Just the honest ones.

"Stop acting like I only exist when you respond to me."

That made something in her jaw tighten.

She looked away first.

Not fully stepping back, but breaking eye contact like it was suddenly too direct.

"You're not making this easy," she said.

Austin nodded once.

"I stopped trying to."

A pause.

"Easy was keeping things from changing."

Silence didn't feel empty anymore.

It felt structured.

Like it had weight.

"So what is this now?" Jenny asked.

Austin's gaze stayed on her.

He didn't rush the answer.

He didn't soften it either.

"This is what it looks like when neither of us leaves."

Jenny's fingers loosened around the cloth without her realizing she had been holding it that tightly.

"And if I want to leave?" she asked.

Not as a challenge.

More like a test she wasn't sure she wanted answered.

Austin didn't step forward this time.

He didn't try to hold her in place.

He just answered.

"Then you would."

A pause.

"But you haven't."

That was all.

No pull.

No insistence.

Just fact.

Jenny took a step back without meaning to.

It wasn't escape.

It was pressure shifting inside her body, needing space she didn't have a name for.

The room felt the same.

But she didn't.

Something about her posture had changed without permission.

"I don't know what I am in this anymore," she said quietly.

Austin watched her for a long moment.

Then—

"I know."

A pause.

"But you're not outside it."

That landed differently now.

Not like definition.

Like recognition of something already occurring.

Jenny swallowed, her voice smaller than before.

"I don't think I can stay halfway in this anymore."

That sentence hung longer than she expected it to.

Austin didn't respond immediately.

For the first time, the pause didn't feel like control.

It felt like understanding the weight of what she had just said.

Then—

"Neither can I," he said.

Jenny looked up at him again.

For a long moment, neither of them moved.

The restaurant continued around them like nothing had changed.

But the space between them had stopped behaving like something flexible.

It felt... settled.

Not resolved.

Not finished.

Just no longer pretending it could go back to what it was.

"So what happens now?" Jenny asked.

Her voice didn't sound like resistance anymore.

It sounded like someone standing at the edge of something they had already stepped onto without noticing.

Austin met her gaze.

And this time, he didn't frame it like a plan.

He didn't structure it.

He just said it as it was.

"Now you stop fighting what you already see."

A pause.

"And decide how you live inside it."

Jenny didn't answer.

Not yet.

But she didn't look away either.

And for the first time, it wasn't because she was being pulled forward.

It was because she had finally stopped pretending she wasn't already there.